HALCYON
LITERARY HOUSE

A FIELD GUIDE FOR INDEPENDENT AUTHORS

The Indie Author Growth Roadmap

How to find the right next move for your book, make it in the right order, and build a readership that lasts beyond launch week.

Halcyon Literary House
halcyonliterary.com

Complimentary edition
22 pages

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Most books are not failing. They are waiting.

Waiting for a cover that signals the right genre. For a description that makes a stranger stop scrolling. For the first fifty readers who will tell the next five hundred.

Every week we speak with authors who have done something brave and difficult: they finished a book. Many have already spent money on promotion that did not move the needle. Almost always, the problem is not the book and not the effort. It is the order in which things were done.

Advertising a book whose cover sends the wrong signal is expensive. Chasing reviews before the listing converts wastes the readers you win. Building a launch around a channel your reader does not use spends your best moment on the wrong audience.

> *Growth is rarely about doing more. It is about doing the right thing next.*

This roadmap is the framework our team uses with every author we take on, simplified so you can apply it yourself. It will help you see where your book stands today, which move will make the biggest difference now, and what can safely wait.

How to use this guide

1. **Find your stage** on page 4. It tells you which chapters matter most right now.
2. **Take the Growth Scorecard** on page 5. Fifteen minutes, honest answers, one clear picture.
3. **Work through your weakest area first**, using the worksheets as you go.
4. **Commit to the 90-day plan** on page 17, and review your score again at the end.

Keep a pen nearby. This guide is meant to be written in.

The team at Halcyon Literary House

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The four questions this guide answers

1. Is my book ready to be bought?
2. Does the right reader understand it instantly?
3. How will readers find it, and in what order?
4. How do I keep them for the next book?

START HERE

Where is your book today?

Every book sits at one of five stages. Find yours, and you will know which part of this roadmap deserves your attention first.

1 **Writing or editing**

The manuscript is still taking shape. The best marketing decisions you can make now are about genre, title and the reader you are writing for.

BEGIN WITH
Part two, then part four

2 **Preparing to publish**

The words are finished. Cover, interior, metadata and a launch window are the decisions that will shape the first ninety days.

BEGIN WITH
Part one, then part two

3 **Published, but hard to discover**

The book is live, but sales are slow and reviews are few. This is the most common stage, and usually the most fixable.

BEGIN WITH
Part two, then part three

4 **Planning a launch or relaunch**

A new release, a series instalment, or a second chance for an earlier book. Timing and sequence matter more here than budget.

BEGIN WITH
Part three and the 90-day plan

5 **Building long-term growth**

You have readers. Now the goal is a platform you own, a backlist that sells itself, and a name that hosts and media recognise.

BEGIN WITH
Part four

A USEFUL RULE

If you are unsure between two stages, choose the earlier one. Problems in the foundation always cost more to fix later.

THE GROWTH SCORECARD

Score your book honestly

For each statement, give **2 points** if it is fully true, **1 point** if it is partly true, and **0** if it is not true or you are not sure.

FOUNDATION

My cover looks like a bestseller in my genre when shrunk to thumbnail size.	0 · 1 · 2
My interior has been professionally formatted for print and ebook.	0 · 1 · 2
The manuscript has been edited by someone other than me.	0 · 1 · 2
My book is available in every format my readers expect.	0 · 1 · 2

POSITION

I can describe my book's promise in one sentence a stranger understands.	0 · 1 · 2
My description opens with a hook, not background or a biography.	0 · 1 · 2
I chose my categories and keywords from research, not guesswork.	0 · 1 · 2
I can name three recent, successful books my readers also love.	0 · 1 · 2

PATH TO READERS

My book has enough reviews to reassure a new reader.	0 · 1 · 2
I know which one or two channels my readers actually use.	0 · 1 · 2
I have a written launch or promotion plan with dates.	0 · 1 · 2
I measure results and stop what does not work.	0 · 1 · 2

READER RELATIONSHIPS

I have an email list, and I write to it regularly.	0 · 1 · 2
The back of my book invites readers to join that list.	0 · 1 · 2
Readers can find me at a website I own.	0 · 1 · 2
Book clubs or reading groups have discussed my book.	0 · 1 · 2

AUTHORITY

I have a short author biography that makes readers trust me.	0 · 1 · 2
I know the story behind my book that a host would want to hear.	0 · 1 · 2
I have a press kit: photo, biography, cover and talking points.	0 · 1 · 2
I have appeared on a podcast, blog, panel or in local media.	0 · 1 · 2

What your score means

Add up each area (out of 8) and your total (out of 40). Your **lowest area** is where your next move belongs, even if your total is high.

AREA	YOUR SCORE	READ NEXT
Foundation	___ / 8	Part one, page 7
Position	___ / 8	Part two, page 9
Path to readers	___ / 8	Part three, page 12
Reader relationships	___ / 8	Part four, page 15
Authority	___ / 8	Part four, page 16
Total	___ / 40	

0–15

Build the base

Promotion will struggle until the foundation and positioning are fixed. This is good news: these are one-time investments that make every later effort cheaper.

16–29

Fix the leak

The essentials are in place, but one or two areas are quietly costing you readers. Address your lowest area before spending more on promotion.

30–40

Scale what works

Your book is ready to grow. The opportunity now is reach and retention: larger campaigns, book clubs, media, and a platform that compounds.

> *A score of 0 in any single area is worth more attention than a total that looks healthy.*

Keep this page. Take the scorecard again at the end of your 90-day plan and compare.

PART ONE

Your publishing foundation

Readers judge a book in the time it takes to scroll past it. Before anyone reads a word, your cover, your interior and your listing have already made a promise about quality.

The retail-ready standard

A retail-ready book is indistinguishable, at a glance, from the traditionally published titles beside it. That is the bar. Not "good for an indie book". Simply good.

The cover

Your cover has one job: to tell the right reader, instantly, "this is your kind of book". Genre conventions are not a limitation; they are a language readers already speak. A thriller that looks like literary fiction will be skipped by thriller readers and disappoint literary ones.

The thumbnail test: shrink your cover to the size of a fingernail beside the top twenty books in your category. Can you still read the title? Does it belong?

The interior

Readers forgive a plot twist they did not expect. They rarely forgive a page that feels amateur. Consistent margins, proper chapter openings, no widows or orphans, and a clean ebook that reflows on every device.

The look-inside test: open the preview on a phone. The first page a reader sees should be your story, not three pages of front matter.

Edit before you spend

No campaign can outrun early reviews that mention typos. Professional editing is the least visible investment and the one that protects every other investment you make.

> WHEN TO BRING IN A HOUSE
>
> If your cover was designed before you knew your exact genre, or your book was formatted with a free template, our **Edition** service prepares your book to retail standard for print and ebook.

PART ONE · WORKSHEET

The foundation checklist

Tick each item only when it is fully done. Anything unticked is a priority before you promote.

COVER

- [ ] Matches the conventions of my exact subgenre
- [ ] Title readable at thumbnail size
- [ ] Designed by a professional cover designer
- [ ] Full wrap for paperback, with spine and back copy
- [ ] Correct trim size, bleed and resolution

INTERIOR

- [ ] Professionally edited and proofread
- [ ] Formatted for print with correct margins
- [ ] Ebook tested on phone, tablet and e-reader
- [ ] Front matter kept short; story starts early
- [ ] Back matter invites readers to your list and next book

FORMATS AND FILES

- [ ] Ebook available
- [ ] Paperback available
- [ ] Hardcover or large print considered
- [ ] Audiobook considered for my genre
- [ ] Files pass KDP and retailer checks

LISTING

- [ ] Series name and number set correctly
- [ ] Author name consistent across all books
- [ ] Author page claimed, with photo and biography
- [ ] Editorial reviews or praise added where possible
- [ ] Price checked against similar books in my genre

MY THREE FOUNDATION PRIORITIES

PART TWO

Your position in the market

No amount of promotion can rescue a book that sends the wrong signal. Positioning is how the right reader understands your book in seconds, and the wrong reader politely moves on.

The three-second test

Show your book's page to someone who reads your genre but has never heard of it. Give them three seconds. Then ask: what kind of book is this, and who is it for? If their answer does not match yours, your positioning needs work, and every pound, dollar or naira spent on promotion is working against it.

The five signals every listing sends

SIGNAL	WHAT IT TELLS THE READER	COMMON MISTAKE
Cover	Genre, tone and quality, before anything else	Designed for the author's taste, not the reader's
Title and subtitle	Subject, mood, and in non-fiction, the outcome	Clever but unclear
Description	The promise: what the reader will feel or gain	A plot summary that gives away too much
Categories and keywords	Where the book appears, and beside whom	Broad categories with heavy competition
Author story	Why you, and why this book	A biography that lists jobs, not credibility

> *Readers do not buy books. They buy the experience a book promises. Your job is to make that promise unmistakable.*

When all five signals agree, something changes. Advertising becomes cheaper because the right people click. Reviews become warmer because readers got what they expected. Recommendations follow naturally.

PART TWO · WORKSHEET

A description that sells

Your book description is a sales page, not a summary. Readers decide in the first two lines whether to tap "read more". Use this structure, then cut every word that does not earn its place.

1 · THE HOOK

One or two lines that create a question the reader needs answered. Lead with tension, not setting.

2 · THE WORLD AND THE STAKES

Who is this about, what do they want, and what stands in the way? Keep it to the first act.

3 · THE PROMISE

The feeling or result the reader will get: heart-pounding, healing, swoon-worthy, practical.

4 · THE PROOF AND THE CALL

Comparable titles ("for readers of…"), praise or awards, then a clear invitation to start reading.

MY ONE-SENTENCE PROMISE

"[Book title] is a [genre] for readers who love [comparable book or feeling], about [character or subject] who must [challenge] before [stakes]."

MY HOOK (TWO LINES, MAXIMUM)

THE FEELING OR RESULT MY READER IS BUYING

FOR READERS OF… (THREE RECENT, SUCCESSFUL COMPARABLE TITLES)

PART TWO

Categories, keywords and comparable titles

Categories decide which shelf your book sits on. Keywords decide which searches it appears in. Comparable titles decide which readers the algorithm shows it to next.

Categories

Choose the most specific categories that honestly describe your book. A niche category where you can reach the top of the list is worth more than a broad one where you are invisible. Look at the top books in each candidate category: if they are not books your reader would also buy, it is the wrong shelf.

Keywords

Amazon gives you seven keyword slots. Think like a reader typing into a search bar: tropes, settings, character types, moods and themes. Avoid repeating words already in your title or categories, and never use other authors' names.

Comparable titles

Your "comps" are recent books (ideally from the last three years) that share your readers. They guide your cover, shape your description, target your advertising, and help book clubs and hosts understand you instantly.

Good comps are successful but not giant. "For fans of a debut that sold well last year" is more useful than naming the biggest book of the decade.

Goodreads

Goodreads is where committed readers keep their to-read lists. Claim your author profile, make sure every edition is linked, and treat it as a second home for your book, not an afterthought.

WHEN TO BRING IN A HOUSE

If your book is live but the three-second test fails, our **Signal** service audits your Amazon listing, rewrites your description, rebuilds your categories and keywords, and sets up your Goodreads strategy.

PART THREE

Your path to readers

The most expensive marketing mistake is not choosing the wrong channel. It is using the right channel at the wrong time.

The order of operations

Each step makes the next one cheaper and more effective. Skip one, and the steps after it work against you.

STEP	MOVE	WHY IT COMES HERE
1	Foundation and position	Every visitor you send to a weak listing is a reader you paid for and lost.
2	First reviews	Reviews are the proof that makes strangers trust you. Paid traffic converts poorly without them.
3	Email promotions and newsletters	Reach readers already looking for books like yours, often for a fixed, modest cost.
4	Advertising	Once the page converts, ads let you scale what already works, and stop what does not.
5	Communities and short-form video	Word of mouth amplifies a book that readers are already enjoying.
6	Platform and authority	Turns one book's readers into an audience for every book that follows.

One hook, many channels

Before you choose channels, find your book's strongest hook: the trope, question or feeling that makes readers say "I need this". Then say the same thing everywhere. A campaign where the newsletter, the ad and the video all lead with the same hook feels like momentum. One where each says something different feels like noise.

PART THREE

Choosing your channels

You do not need to be everywhere. You need to be where your reader already is, with enough consistency to be noticed. Choose one or two channels, and do them well.

CHANNEL	BEST FOR	WORKS WHEN	WATCH OUT FOR
Email promotions	Launches, price promotions, first wave of readers and reviews	The book has a strong cover and clear genre	Sites with lists that do not match your genre
Newsletter swaps and placements	Reaching readers of similar authors	Your comps are well chosen	Partners whose readers want a different tone
Amazon advertising	Steady, measurable sales once the page converts	You have reviews and a tested description	Spending before the listing is ready
BookTok and short-form video	Romance, fantasy, thriller and emotionally driven fiction	The hook can be shown in seconds	Posting without a clear, repeated hook
Goodreads	Building to-read lists and early reviews	Your profile and editions are set up properly	Treating it as a place to advertise rather than connect
Book clubs and reading groups	Deep reviews and discussion, long after launch	The book sparks conversation	Approaching groups without a reading guide
Podcasts and media	Non-fiction, memoir, and authors with a strong personal story	You have a timely angle and a press kit	Pitching the book instead of the story

Measure what matters

For every channel, track three things: what it cost, what it returned in sales or page reads, and what it returned in reviews and sign-ups. Give a channel a fair test, then decide. Stop anything that does not earn its place within a month.

PART THREE

Reviews, the quiet engine

Reviews do more than reassure. They feed the recommendation engines, unlock promotion opportunities, and give your next campaign something to stand on.

Ways to earn reviews honestly

- **Advance readers.** Invite readers to receive an early copy in exchange for an honest review on release.
- **Your back matter.** A short, sincere request on the last page, when the reader's feelings are strongest.
- **Your email list.** Ask your most engaged readers personally. They are often glad to help.
- **Goodreads.** Giveaways and reader groups build to-read lists, which become reviews.
- **Book clubs.** Group discussions produce thoughtful, detailed reviews.
- **Email promotions.** A well-targeted promotion brings a wave of new readers, and reviews follow.

What to avoid

- Paying for reviews, or offering anything in exchange for a positive one.
- Reviews from family and close friends, which retailers may remove.
- Review swaps with other authors.
- Responding publicly to negative reviews.

These shortcuts can lead to removed reviews or an account suspension, and they rarely produce the readers you actually want.

A simple goal

Aim for a steady flow of genuine reviews over time rather than a burst at launch. A book that keeps gathering reviews looks alive to readers and to retailers.

WHEN TO BRING IN A HOUSE

Our **Launch** service builds and runs your campaign across email promotions, newsletters, Amazon ads and short-form video, around one hook and one plan.

PART FOUR

Lasting reader relationships

Attention fades after launch week. Relationships do not. The authors who grow book after book are the ones who own a direct line to their readers.

Own your audience

Retailers, social platforms and algorithms change their rules without warning. An email list and a website are the only parts of your career you truly own. Every campaign should send readers somewhere you control.

Your website

A simple, beautiful home with your books, your story, where to buy, and an invitation to join your list. It is the address you give hosts, readers and the press.

Your newsletter

Write regularly, even briefly. Share what you are writing, what you are reading and why. Readers who hear from you are readers who buy your next book on day one.

Your reader gift

A bonus chapter, short story, character art or reading guide, offered free in exchange for an email address. It turns a one-time reader into a lasting one.

The back of your book is prime real estate

The moment a reader finishes your book is the moment they are most likely to act. Use it: a short thank-you, a request for an honest review, an invitation to your list with a reader gift, and a link to your next book. Most authors leave this page empty.

WHEN TO BRING IN A HOUSE

Our **Estate** service designs and builds your author brand, website, newsletter, automations and reader gifts, so every campaign has a home to send readers to.

PART FOUR

Book clubs, communities and your story

Book clubs and reading groups

A book club does not read your book once. It discusses it, recommends it, and returns to it. One good fit can produce more thoughtful reviews than weeks of advertising.

- Prepare a reading guide with eight to ten discussion questions.
- Approach groups whose recent picks resemble your book.
- Offer a short author Q&A, online or in person.
- Follow up with thanks, and an invitation to your list.

Library groups, online communities and genre forums work the same way: lead with generosity and fit, never with a sales pitch.

Your story, your authority

Hosts and journalists rarely want to talk about a book. They want to talk about a story: why you wrote it, what you know, and why it matters now.

- **Find your angle.** What personal experience, expertise or timely question does your book connect to?
- **Prepare a press kit.** Professional photo, short and long biography, cover, summary and five talking points.
- **Start close to home.** Local media, niche podcasts and genre blogs lead to larger stages.
- **Practise.** A clear, warm two-minute answer to "tell us about your book" opens doors.

THE STORY BEHIND MY BOOK, IN TWO SENTENCES

WHEN TO BRING IN A HOUSE

Circle places your book with book clubs and reading communities and arranges author Q&As. **Press** shapes your story and leads outreach to podcasts and media.

YOUR 90-DAY PLAN

Ninety days, three phases

Ninety days is long enough to see real change and short enough to stay focused. Each phase builds on the one before it.

DAYS 1 TO 30

Repair the base

- Take the scorecard and choose your lowest area
- Run the thumbnail and three-second tests
- Rewrite your description using the worksheet
- Research and update categories and keywords
- Choose three comparable titles
- Update your back matter with a list invitation
- Set up or refresh your Goodreads profile

DAYS 31 TO 60

Win the first readers

- Define your hook, and use it everywhere
- Recruit advance or early readers for reviews
- Book one or two well-matched email promotions
- Arrange newsletter placements with similar authors
- Create a reader gift for your email list
- Prepare a reading guide for book clubs
- Track cost, sales, reviews and sign-ups weekly

DAYS 61 TO 90

Scale and keep

- Repeat the promotions that worked; stop the rest
- Test a small Amazon advertising budget
- Approach three book clubs or reading groups
- Send your list a regular update
- Pitch one podcast or local media outlet
- Plan your next book's launch with your list
- Take the scorecard again and compare

> *Consistency beats intensity. Two hours a week for ninety days will outperform one exhausting weekend.*

YOUR 90-DAY PLAN · WORKSHEET

Your weekly rhythm

Block the same time each week. Use this page to plan the first month, then copy it for the next two.

WEEK	MY FOCUS THIS WEEK	DONE WHEN…	RESULT
1			
2			
3			
4			

My numbers

MEASURE	DAY 1	DAY 30	DAY 60	DAY 90
Total reviews				
Monthly sales				
Email subscribers				
Scorecard total				

THE ONE RESULT THAT WOULD MAKE THESE NINETY DAYS A SUCCESS

LESSONS FROM OTHER AUTHORS

Three books, three different problems

Each of these authors needed something different. None of them needed everything. The result came from solving the right problem first.

1,800

reviews, from a start of about 70 sales

LAUNCH · EMAIL AND NEWSLETTER PROMOTION

Callista Arden

A new author with about 70 sales, mostly from friends and family, and no experience of book marketing. We placed the book in email promotions and reader newsletters suited to its audience. The book reached 560 reviews after the first campaign. When it worked, we ran it again, and the book reached 1,800 reviews.

The lesson: when a campaign works, repeat it before you look for something new.

200+

reviews in two months

CIRCLE · BOOK CLUB CAMPAIGN

Kit Rose

A published book with fewer than 30 reviews. We found book clubs and reading groups suited to the book, introduced it to their organisers and coordinated the discussions. The book went from under 30 reviews to more than 200 within two months.

The lesson: readers who discuss a book together review it thoughtfully, and in numbers.

90+

sales in one month

SIGNAL · AMAZON AUDIT AND GOODREADS

Christina Rozelle

A published book that was not reaching the readers it was written for. We audited and fixed the book's Amazon listing, then promoted it to readers on Goodreads. The book sold more than 90 copies in a single month.

The lesson: fix the listing before you send anyone to it.

COMMON QUESTIONS

What authors ask us most

How much should I spend on marketing?

Less than you think, at first. Spend on the foundation and positioning before promotion, then test promotion in small amounts and grow only what returns its cost.

Is it too late for a book published years ago?

Rarely. Many books find their readers in a relaunch, with a refreshed cover, a new description and better categories. A book is new to every reader who has not found it yet.

Should I lower my price?

A short price promotion can introduce your book to many new readers, especially when paired with an email promotion. Permanent low prices are a strategy, not a fix for weak positioning.

Do I need social media?

Not necessarily. You need to be where your readers are. For some genres that is short-form video; for others it is newsletters, Goodreads or book clubs.

How long until I see results?

Positioning changes can show results within weeks. Campaigns and reviews build over one to three months. A lasting readership is built over several books.

Should I write the next book or market this one?

Both, in balance. Your next book is the best marketing for your last one, especially in a series. A few focused hours of marketing each week will not cost you your writing.

Does Kindle Unlimited make sense for me?

It depends on your genre. Readers of romance, fantasy and thrillers often read heavily through subscription. Compare where the top books in your category are available.

When should I get professional help?

When you know what needs to change but not how, or when your time is better spent writing. The right partner should tell you what not to do as clearly as what to do.

BEFORE YOU SPEND ANOTHER DOLLAR

Ten costly mistakes

We see the same patterns again and again. Each one quietly drains budget, energy or goodwill, and each has a simple alternative.

	THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
1	Advertising before the listing converts	Fix cover, description and reviews first, then scale.
2	A cover designed for the author, not the reader	Follow the conventions of your exact subgenre.
3	A description that summarises the plot	Lead with a hook and sell the experience.
4	Broad, crowded categories	Choose specific shelves where your book can be seen.
5	Trying to be on every platform	Choose one or two channels and be consistent.
6	A different message on every channel	Find one hook and repeat it everywhere.
7	Buying reviews or trading them	Earn reviews from advance readers, clubs and promotions.
8	No email list	Offer a reader gift and invite readers in your back matter.
9	Stopping after launch week	Plan ninety days, not seven, and keep the book alive.
10	Not measuring results	Track cost, sales, reviews and sign-ups for every effort.

> *Every one of these is fixable. Most can be fixed in a single afternoon.*

YOUR NEXT STEP

Your book deserves a house.

You now know where your book stands. If you would like a senior team to look at it with you, we offer a private consultation to authors we believe we can help.

In your consultation

- We review your book, listing and goals before we speak
- We tell you honestly what is working and what is not
- We recommend the one or two moves that matter most now
- We tell you what can wait, or what you can do yourself

One house, six disciplines

Edition	Book production
Signal	Positioning and discoverability
Launch	Book marketing
Circle	Reader connections
Estate	Author platform
Press	PR and authority

Request a private consultation

halcyonliterary.com/contact · hello@halcyonliterary.com

HALCYON
LITERARY HOUSE

A private literary house for independent authors.

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